

MOURNING A TITAN Himanta Biswa Sarma pays tribute to Zubeen Garg at Delhi airport, Sept. 21; Left, the charismatic singer who millions idolised; below, Rahul Gandhi at Zubeen's funeral site in Sonapur, Oct. 17



Photographs by ANI

"If I resign today, 50 per cent of the protests will end immediately. And if Gaurav Gogoi is made chief minister, the remaining 50 per cent will also stop"

HIMANTA BISWA SARMA
Chief Minister, Assam, alleging a Congress hand in violent protests on Oct. 15 over Zubeen Garg's death

Medical College Hospital just hours before Zubeen's cremation on September 23. Viscera samples were sent to Delhi's Central Forensic Science Laboratory to check for toxins, addressing conspiracy theories ranging from negligence to poisoning. A 10-member special investigation team was formed with a two-week deadline for preliminary findings. The government also appointed a one-man judicial commission headed by a retired judge to probe systemic lapses.

The politically astute Sarma seemed determined to prevent the kind of Gen Z unrest seen in Nepal. On September 25, when a mob attempted to storm Siddhartha's Guwahati home, precipitating a police lathicharge, Sarma appealed: "Don't turn Assam into Nepal. Don't weaponise Zubeen's death." The 'Nepal' warning resurfaced on October 7, when Sarma vowed to file cases against those "provoking unrest" over Zubeen's death.

REVIVING AN ALIEN SPECTRE

Even opposition leaders like Gaurav Gogoi will be questioned," Sarma vowed, adding that police would register an omnibus case similar to those filed during the protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) of 2019. The comparison was significant. Like many Assamese, Zubeen had vehemently opposed the CAA, a sentiment the Opposition is now seeking to revive. The anti-CAA agitation had lost steam, and the BJP returned to power in 2021, with Sarma firmly defending the law. The CAA reference was a reminder to the Opposition of that lost battle.

As demands for accountability intensified, authorities responded with a flurry of arrests that transformed the case from an accident probe into a criminal inquiry. On October 1, the CID arrested Shyamkanu and Siddhartha on charges of culpable homicide not amounting to murder. But aware that the case was legally weak, the government activated financial irregularity charges and brought in the Enforcement Directorate to probe Shyamkanu's past financial deals.

The plot thickened when Shekhar, one of Zubeen's bandmates who was present in Singapore, told the police that Zubeen had been poisoned by Shyamkanu and Siddhartha, contradicting his earlier statements asserting death by drowning. On this basis, the police upgraded the case to murder